STAYMAN CONVENTION

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

STAYMAN CONVENTION SUMMARY

When one partner opens 1NT it is difficult to uncover a 4-4 Major fit using only natural bidding. The Stayman Convention solves the problem and improves bidding accuracy as well. As an additional benefit, when you use Stayman the 1NT Opener usually becomes the Declarer on the hand, thereby keeping the stronger hand concealed.

The Stayman Convention is worthwhile even if it is the only convention you use. However, there are added benefits to using Stayman in conjunction with Jacoby Transfers. The two work smoothly together with Stayman taking care of those hands where Responder has a 4-card Major(s) and Jacoby Transfers taking care of those hands where Responder has a 5- or 6-card Major.

The actual working of Stayman is simple:
Following a 1NT opening, Responder will only use Stayman when he holds at least one 4-card Major suit.
He does so by bidding 2♣ which requires Opener to reply as follows:

- With no 4-card Major suit he bids 2♦.
- With a 4-card ♥ suit, (and possibly 4 ♠s as well), he bids 2♥.
- With a 4-card ♠ suit, (but not 4 ♥s), he bids 2♠.

It really is as simple as that. Well, almost.

Stayman takes much of the guesswork (sometimes called judgement) out of the bidding and steers you directly to these two goals:

1. With a partnership 26 points you will reach game, with 33 you will reach slam.
2. With a partnership 8+ cards in a Major suit you will play in that suit, otherwise you will play notrump.

For the first point consider this table which is based on the 1NT opener holding 15-17 points.

Resp Points	Opener Points			Bidding Target
	15	16	17	
8	23	24	25	Partscore
9	24	25	26	
10	25	26	27	
11	26	27	28	
12	27	28	29	Game
13	28	29	30	
14	29	30	31	
15	30	31	32	
16	31	32	33	
17	32	33	34	Slam
18	33	34	35	

Responder's actions are as follows:

- 8 points or fewer - usually pass, but may use Stayman and then pass
- 9 points - invite partner to game
- 10 points - either invite or force to game, using your judgement
- 11-15 points - force to game
- 16 points - invite to slam
- 17 points - either invite or force to slam, using your judgement
- 18 points or more - force to slam

Opener's actions are as follows:

- 15 points - decline invitations
- 16 points - either decline or accept, using your judgement
- 17 points - accept invitations

As to the second point above (the 8-card trump fit) Responder is usually in charge.

- If Opener shows a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks that suit.
- If Opener does not show a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks notrump.

Opener usually has no say in the suit selection, with this important exception:
If Opener holds 4 cards in **EACH** Major suit he responds 2♥.
Should Responder then bid notrump, indicating a dislike for ♥s, Opener should bid ♠s because she knows there is a 4-4 ♠ fit,

Some comments are in order about the point count methods used on these pages.
Initial point count for both hands is based on 4-3-2-1 plus one point for a fifth card in a suit.
Revalued points (only after a trump fit is discovered) are +1 for a doubleton, +2 for a singleton and +3 for a void. Both hands should count these revalued short-suit points; Opener of course would not have a singleton or void.

One more point. Stayman should definitely be used after 2NT openings as well.

25 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣7

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣7

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦J

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥4

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K Q 5
♥ Q 9 5
♦ K Q 9 4
♣ A 6 2

♠ J 8 6 3
♥ 4 3 2
♦ 8 6 3
♣ J 9 8



♠ 7 2
♥ A 8 6
♦ 10 7 5 2
♣ 10 7 5 4

♠ A 10 9 4
♥ K J 10 7
♦ A J
♣ K Q 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♣7

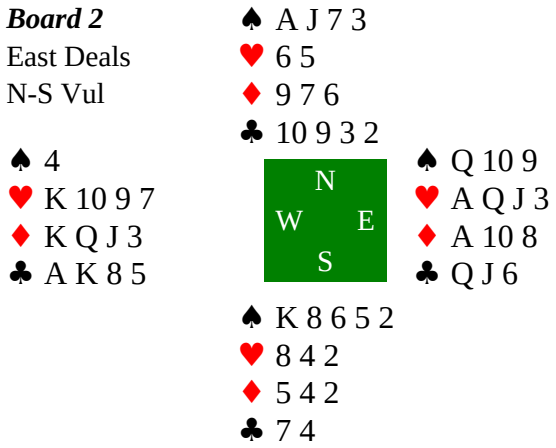
North opens 1NT.

You have a very big hand. Enormous. But you also have two 4-card Majors, so the first step is Stayman. You bid 2♣ and partner replies 2♦.

You have 18 points and partner has 15, 16 or 17. Your total is between 33 and 35. You have enough POINTS for a small slam, not enough for a grand. You have no Major suit fit, and are happy to play notrump.

There is a lot to be said for bidding 6NT immediately. You could ask for Aces if you like but whether partner shows one or two isn't going to change your decision. Be bold.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♥ by East
Lead: ♣7

East opens 1NT.

You have another big hand. And with a 4-card Major you start with 2♣. Partner answers 2♥ and it's your turn again.

What with your singleton ♠ you certainly have enough points for slam. But since it's possible partner has only one Ace you check with Blackwood. Partner says 5♥ and you say . . . What?

Missing one Ace you bid 6♥.

Board 3
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A K Q 4 2 ♥ J 10 7 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ 9 3	
♠ 10 8 6 ♥ 4 3 ♦ J 10 2 ♣ A J 10 7 6	N W E S	♠ J 7 3 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ Q 9 8 4 ♣ 5 4 2
	♠ 9 5 ♥ K Q 9 5 ♦ A K 6 3 ♣ K Q 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♦J

South opens 1NT.

This may go against your instincts, but if you're going to play Stayman then you should follow the rules. Granted that you have a great ♠ suit, you also have 4 ♥s. And when you have a 4-card Major you use Stayman. You bid 2♣ and partner says 2♥.

That is why you used Stayman - to uncover a 4-4 Major suit fit. Having done so you know that you will play in ♥s and you have enough points to bid game. You bid 4♥.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 7 ♥ A 8 4 3 ♦ K Q J 2 ♣ J 4 2	
♠ A K Q 4 2 ♥ J 10 7 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ 9 3		♠ 10 8 6 ♥ K Q 5 ♦ A 8 6 4 ♣ A K 10
	♠ 9 5 3 ♥ 9 2 ♦ 10 9 3 ♣ Q 8 7 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♦K

East opens 1NT.

Yes, this is the same hand as Deal 8. Again you bid 2♣10his time partner says 2♦.

You need to describe your hand clearly to partner with this bid. You want to show a game-forcing hand (11 points or more) with 4 ♥s and 5 ♠s. You do that by now jumping to 3♠.

If partner had just 2 ♠s he would have bid 3NT. Since he has 3 ♠s he bids 4♠.

Board 5
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q J 9 ♥ K J ♦ Q 7 6 4 ♣ Q 5 3	
♠ 6 5 3 ♥ 5 2 ♦ A 10 8 5 3 ♣ A J 10		♠ 8 7 ♥ 8 7 4 ♦ K J 9 2 ♣ K 9 6 2
	♠ K 10 4 2 ♥ A Q 10 9 6 3 ♦ — ♣ 8 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥4

North opens 1NT.

Even when you hold a 6-card Major, if you have 4 cards in the other Major you use Stayman. Partner answers 2♠.

You've found an 8-card Major fit and you know there are enough points for game. So you bid 4♠.

Yes, but you already knew you had an 8-card ♥ fit since partner's 1NT promised at least 2 ♥s. In fact, you could play game in either Major. However, it is often better to play in a 4-4 fit rather than a 5-3 or 6-2. This hand shows why. Played in ♥s you will make exactly 10 tricks with any opening lead. Played in ♠s you will again make 10 tricks when the defenders start with their 3 ♣ winners. If they start with anything else you are very likely to make 1 or 2 overtricks by discarding dummy losers on your ♥ suit.